

Preliminary Site Assessments — Cormsil, Yorkshire

Seven sites identified for initial survey. Assessments compiled from public records, satellite imagery, and advance reconnaissance. Analysis pending.

L1 — Cormsil Village (General)

L1

PRELIMINARY ASSESSMENT

A small agricultural settlement of approximately 400 residents in the Yorkshire Dales. The village is centered on a green with a medieval market cross (stone, worn by weathering). Key structures include: one licensed public house (The Dömere Arms — the name's etymology is locally unknown, not appearing in standard English place-name dictionaries); one Norman-era church (St. Cuthbert's, 12th century, active parish); one public library (currently a fire-damaged structure — see L2); one primary school; and scattered residential and agricultural properties. The village economy is agricultural (sheep farming, some dairy). The village is not a tourist destination and sees limited outside visitors. The atmosphere is described by advance reconnaissance as "tense" — residents appear socially divided, with reduced public interaction observed. Some residents avoid eye contact with certain other residents. The reasons for this social division are under investigation. A significant event — a fire at the public library approximately three weeks ago — is known to have occurred and may be a contributing factor. The pub is the primary social hub; strangers are noticed quickly.

Accessibility: All shifts. The pub is open Day and Evening. The church is open Day and Evening. The library site is accessible at any time (no guard). Strangers will be noticed — the village is small and insular.

Assessment: Primary area of operations. Social tension and recent fire event warrant investigation. **Source:** public records, satellite imagery, advance reconnaissance.

PRELIMINARY ASSESSMENT

A single-story stone building that previously served as the Cormsil Public Library. The structure was damaged by fire approximately three weeks ago. Current condition: roof collapsed inward, interior gutted. Surviving features include stone walls and partial shelving. The site is cordoned with police tape but is not actively guarded. No fire investigation report has been filed with the North Yorkshire Fire and Rescue Service as of the most recent records check — this is unusual for a structure fire involving a public building and may indicate the investigation is ongoing or has been administratively delayed. A glass display case in the former reading room is partially intact — a brass label is legible, reading: "Cormsil Compact, 1882 — On Permanent Loan from the Town Council." The case is empty. The significance of the "Cormsil Compact" is unknown — preliminary research has not identified this document in public records. The library's collection was modest (estimated 5,000–8,000 volumes) and served the local population. The librarian is identified as Eleanor Vane (see NPC1). The fire's cause is unknown. Casualty figures: unconfirmed. Local accounts are contradictory — some residents describe survivors, others refer to fatalities. Official records are pending.

Accessibility: All shifts. The site is accessible — police tape only, no active guard. Night visits require a light source. Exercise caution: structural instability is possible (collapsed roof).

Assessment: Site of significant event. Fire cause and casualty figures unconfirmed. Display case label ("Cormsil Compact, 1882") may be relevant. **Source:** site observation, public records (incomplete).

PRELIMINARY ASSESSMENT

A Norman-era parish church, 12th century construction, built of local grey stone. The structure is active — regular Sunday services, a sitting vicar (Reverend Paul Threlfall, approximately 12 years in post). The church interior features wooden pews, stained glass windows (agricultural and saint motifs), and a stone floor. The building is listed as a Grade II historic structure by English Heritage. Behind the vestry, stone stairs descend to a crypt — the crypt is older than the church above, possibly pre-Norman (Saxon) in origin. The crypt is not open to the general public; access requires the vicar's permission. Parish records dating to the 19th century are held at the church, including baptismal, marriage, and burial registers. The church's historical association with the village — spanning approximately 900 years — makes its records potentially relevant to understanding the 1882 compact referenced at the library site.

Accessibility: Church: Day and Evening shifts — open to the public. Crypt: requires vicar's permission or discreet entry. Parish records: request to vicar. Night: church locked; infiltration required for access.

Assessment: Potential source of historical records. Pre-Norman crypt noted — age and purpose warrant investigation.
Source: public records, English Heritage listing.

PRELIMINARY ASSESSMENT

A small stone cottage on the edge of Cormsil, set back from the road. The property is the registered residence of Eleanor Vane, the former librarian of the now-destroyed Cormsil Public Library. The garden is overgrown — previously maintained, now neglected for an estimated three to four weeks (consistent with post-fire timeline). Curtains are drawn at all hours observed. The occupant appears to be present (lights visible at night, occasional movement detected) but does not leave the property. External observation notes: multiple visitors arrive daily — individuals, not groups — who enter briefly and depart. The identity of these visitors and the purpose of their visits is under investigation. The occupant is assessed as cooperative — she reportedly answers the door and is willing to speak with visitors. Her physical and psychological condition is described as fragile (see NPC1).

Availability: Day and Evening shifts. The occupant rarely leaves the property. She will reportedly answer the door. Approach with care — her condition is described as fragile.

Assessment: Residence of key witness. Pattern of daily visitors noted — significance unknown. **Source:** property registry, external surveillance.

PRELIMINARY ASSESSMENT

One of the United Kingdom's oldest and most significant research libraries, located in central Oxford. The library's manuscript collection is accessible to qualified researchers with a reader's card. Of potential relevance: the Bodleian holds the personal papers of Arthur Hailes — Vicar of Cormsil, 1876-1891 — including his parish correspondence, personal journals, and a sealed letter addressed to the Bishop of Ripon dated 1883. The letter is catalogued as unopened. The vicar's tenure (1876-1891) encompasses the period of the 1882 compact referenced at the Cormsil library site. The content of Hailes's papers — particularly the sealed letter — may provide historical context for events in Cormsil during his incumbency. The library operates standard academic hours. Manuscript access requires supervision and adherence to handling protocols. The library staff are professional and accustomed to research inquiries.

Availability: Day shifts only. Reading room hours: 9 AM-5 PM, Mon-Sat. Reader's card required. Travel: approximately 2 shifts from Cormsil.

Assessment: Potential source of historical documentation from the period of interest. The sealed letter is noted as unusual. **Source:** public library catalogue.

PRELIMINARY ASSESSMENT

The United Kingdom's national library. Of potential relevance: the manuscript collection includes a 17th-century folio by Sir Geoffrey Colne (1609–1673), a known antiquarian and scholar. The folio — titled in the catalogue as "Of Certain Subterranean Presences in the County of York" (1642) — is catalogued as a study of local folklore and unusual occurrences in Yorkshire, with particular reference to a site near the modern village of Cormsil. Colne was a respected antiquarian of his period — his published works cover Roman Britain, Anglo-Saxon England, and regional folklore. This particular manuscript was never published; it exists only in the British Library's manuscript collection. The manuscript's catalogue entry notes it contains "observations and diagrams" and marginal annotations "in a different hand." The manuscript requires supervised access in the reading room. Photography may be restricted.

Availability: Day shifts only. Reading room hours. Reader's card required. Travel: approximately 3 shifts from Cormsil, 2 from Oxford.

Assessment: Potential source of historical and folkloric context specific to the Cormsil area. Colne's reputation as a scholar suggests rigorous methodology. **Source:** public library catalogue.

PRELIMINARY ASSESSMENT

A weathered stone monolith in a sheep field approximately half a mile from Cormsil village. The stone is taller than a person, grey-green with lichen growth, leaning slightly — consistent with ground settling over centuries. The stone is not listed on English Heritage's scheduled monuments register, suggesting it has not been formally surveyed or dated. Visual assessment suggests pre-Roman origin — possibly Bronze Age or Iron Age, but this is unconfirmed without archaeological survey. The field is privately owned by a local farmer (Tom Dwerryhouse — see NPC2). The stone is accessible on foot across open farmland. The soil around the stone's base is noticeably darker than the surrounding field — a circular discoloration approximately 2 meters in diameter. Grass within this circle is dead or dying. The farmer reportedly checks the stone daily — behavior described by local sources as "recent," i.e., not a long-standing habit. The significance of the stone — if any — to current events is unknown.

Availability: All shifts. The field is private farmland — the owner (Tom Dwerryhouse) may grant or deny access. Without permission, it is accessible on foot across open fields. Exercise discretion — the farmer reportedly visits the site daily.

Assessment: Archaeological feature of potential relevance. Soil discoloration and dead vegetation in a radius around the stone are anomalous — cause unknown. Farmer's recent behavioral change is noted. Source: site observation, local reports (unconfirmed).